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*(AI-Generated Session Notes)*

# The Marketing Engineer's Toolkit: APIs, MCP, Agents, and the Building Blocks Behind Your AI Stack

**Date & time:** Oct. 14, 10:00-10:35 AM
**Track:** Applied AI




## Erica Salm Rench

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## Session Description

Most marketers can prompt an AI tool, but few understand what's actually happening underneath it: the APIs it's calling, the connectors like MCP linking it to real data and systems, the tools and agents doing the work, and the context and memory that make it feel personalized.

Erica Salm Rench runs her entire business on Claude, building and configuring MCP connectors herself rather than just reading about them. In this session, she translates that hands-on experience into a plain-language map marketing engineers can actually use, without a single line of code.

## Key Quote

> *"So congratulations, you are all the most expensive integration layer in your marketing stack."* **- Erica Salm Rench**

## Session Summary

Erica Salm Rench, who runs her own AI growth firm and previously served as CMO of the AI education company Sidecar, opened by asking how many attendees regularly copy and paste output from their AI tools into documents, spreadsheets, or their CRM. Her point: individual prompting is great for experimentation and pilots, but connectivity is where marketing operations really scale. That shift has given rise to the marketing engineer, a role she prefers to call a growth engineer, focused on connecting systems, monitoring and evaluating those connections, and optimizing them without needing to be a coder.

A central theme was that the model is one of the least differentiated parts of an AI stack, since competitors use the same models. Context is the differentiator, from conversations, files, memories, and browser use to skills, which she described as standard operating procedures embedded in AI tools and shareable across an organization. She warned that bad context is worse than no context, because AI fails confidently and quietly, and urged marketers to get their data house in order with clean data, smooth workflows, and well-mapped lifecycle stages and funnels.

Salm Rench then walked through the building blocks. MCP (Model Context Protocol) is a shared language that lets AI tools talk directly to the CRM, email, calendar, and other tools without a custom API integration. She noted it was originally developed by Anthropic in 2024 and is now maintained by the Agentic AI Foundation under the Linux Foundation. APIs still make sense for straightforward, high-volume, one-to-one work like nightly batch updates, while MCP can absorb small field changes and infer missing details. She also touched on RAG and on agents, which pursue goals where the step-by-step path is not obvious.

In live demos of her own stack, including HubSpot, Slack, Gmail, Granola, her calendar, Apollo, and a data enrichment tool, all connected to Claude, she showed a single prompt that created a HubSpot marketing email, landing page, audience segment, and social posts, pulling missing session details from her Gmail. She also showed a self-updating dashboard and a scheduled lead-sourcing task that finds prospects, enriches their data, drafts personalized emails, posts to Slack, and logs records in HubSpot.

She closed by acknowledging that connecting systems is a bigger lift in larger organizations with governance and IT rules. Her recommended first step is to explore which tools offer MCP connectors or APIs, review the actions each connector allows, and treat who chooses the next step as a governance question.

## Key Takeaways

- **Stop being the integration layer:** Regularly copying and pasting between AI tools and other systems is a signal that connectivity, not more prompting, is the next step for scaling marketing operations.
- **Context is the differentiator:** Because competitors use the same models, clean CRM data, well-mapped workflows, and documented SOPs turned into skills are what set your AI output apart.
- **Know when to use MCP vs. APIs:** MCP lets AI tools work directly with your stack and infer missing details, while APIs remain the better fit for simple, high-volume, one-to-one updates.
- **Check the work:** When you first set up connections, verify every action a tool says it completed, much like reviewing an intern's work, until you are comfortable with it.
- **Start with an inventory:** Explore which of your tools have MCP connectors or APIs, review what actions each allows, and press vendors that don't yet offer MCP to build it.